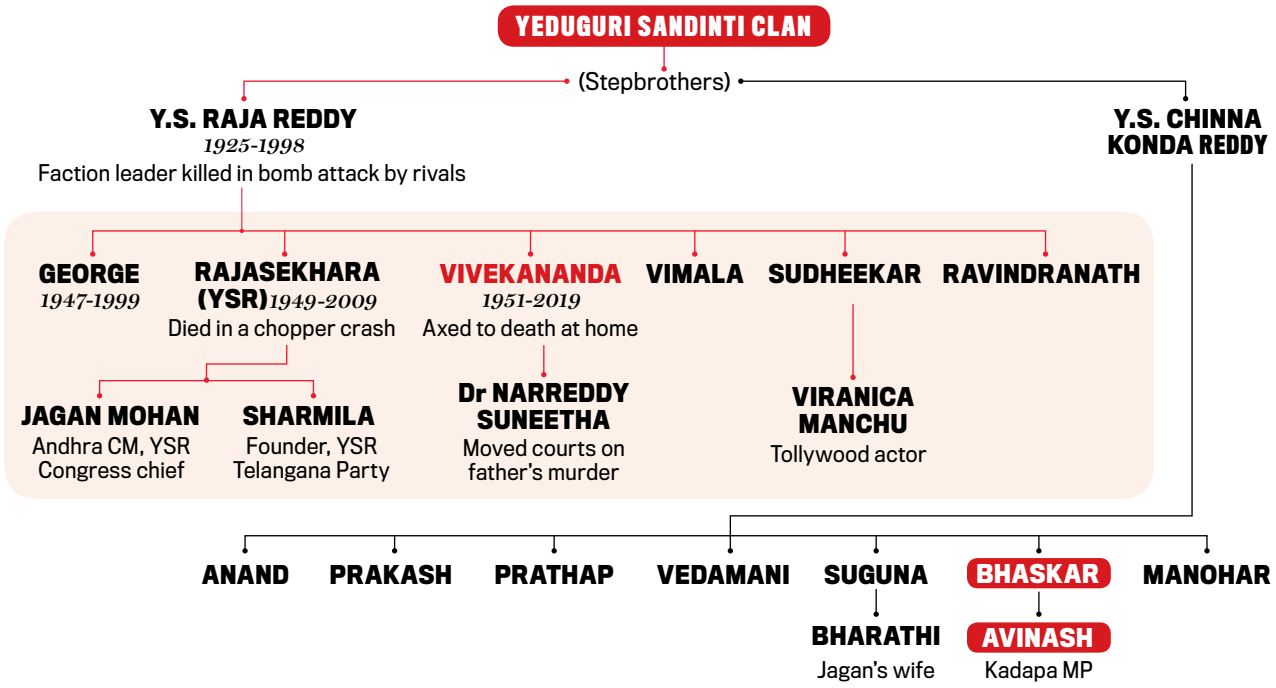


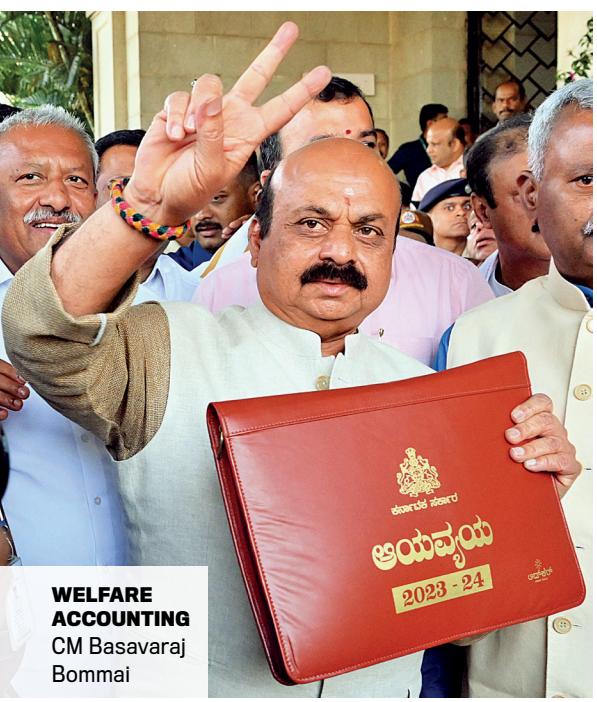


Avinash ensured Vivekananda's defeat in the polls, leading to a falling out between him and the father-son duo. To cut Avinash down to size, Vivekananda opposed his getting the Kadapa Lok Sabha ticket in 2019 and suggested to Jagan that the CM's sister Sharmila or mother Vijayamma be fielded instead. The CBI alleges that Rs 40 crore was offered as payout for the murder.

Avinash, though, rejects the allegations. "When the Telugu Desam Party (TDP) levelled allegations a year ago, the CBI said the same thing in an affidavit. What is needed is a fair probe," the Kadapa MP said on February 24 after appearing for questioning by the CBI for the second time in two months. He added that he had made a representation to the CBI officials and requested an inquiry into the facts he had submitted. "We'll know in the coming days whether the developments till now were the work of Google or the TDP," he added.

The CBI chargesheet comes as an embarrassment for the ruling YSRC, which had all along been claiming that Avinash had no role in the murder as alleged by the opposition TDP. "The murder was committed as per the screenplay and direction of TDP president N. Chandrababu Naidu. It is plain that a conspiracy is being hatched against Jagan keeping the 2024 elections in view," claimed S. Ramakrishna Reddy, YSRC general secretary and advisor (public affairs) to the Andhra government.

The investigation is nowhere near its end. The CBI has so far named 248 people as witnesses. With the general election just a year away, it is certain that the Vivekananda murder case will be grist for propaganda, especially since the Andhra Pradesh assembly polls will also be due by then. ■



WELFARE ACCOUNTING
CM Basavaraj Bommai

ANI

KARNATAKA BUDGET

FOR LOVE OF THE COMMON PEOPLE

By Ajay Sukumaran

Rath yatras—that tried and tested vehicle of the BJP's election campaigning—rolled out on March 1 in Karnataka where the party is in power. Four custom-designed 'election raths' flagged off by central ministers from different corners of Karnataka will wind their way across the state to converge at a grand rally planned at the centrally-located town of Davanagere by the month-end. Despite the intractable problems that have dogged its four-year tenure and a seemingly re-energised Congress, the party is bringing out its big guns into the election battlefield, banking on a slew of welfare programmes